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The Somali tribe

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V. Social consequences of the contacts between pastoralists and agriculturalists in the zone of the rivers.

Now along the river W[unknown]ebi we find that, within the confederation of the Negro [unknown]Sidlä, the villages are always certainly the fundamental political unit, but each village is said to be inhabited by various stirpes, each of which has a name and a genealogy, which -- even if shorter and less elaborate -- tries to resemble the genealogies of the Somali peoples. And even the village of Maggäy, inhabited by the Negro [unknown]Sidlä, is said to be genealogically descended in toto from one progenitor, Maggäy 'Ismân, who might have been a relative, if not a brother, of Abgâl 'Ismân, the progenitor of the well-known Somali tribe. It is probable that these genealogical statements give a nobler aspect to ancient rights of patronage; and it is typical that among the Somalis, corresponding to the claim concerning Maggäy 'Ismân, there is the tradition of the progenitor Abgâl 'Ismân, who, his parents being dead, was nursed and adopted by a Negress, Salâmo-Nâs-[unknown]dêre, which is the subject of ironical jokes on the part of the other tribes (²).

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And, moreover, still along the river W[unknown]ebi, on the strip of "black land," some Somali tribes have occupied whole tillable areas, which today are their permanent residence. These tribes, of the Hawiyya group, have now become agriculturalists, even while having kept, more or less, the ancient occupation of pastoralism. Thus, proceeding on the middle Uebi from the valley upstream: the Hillibi, the D[unknown]a'ûd, of the Bal'ad zone; then the M[unknown]ob[unknown]ilên, today very expert agriculturalists; then the Molkâl, and, finally, the Badi 'Addo. The Hillibi, the D[unknown]a'ûd, and the M[unknown]ob[unknown]ilên, with their territory do not reach as far as the river, whose banks in this sector are held by the Negro villages of the Scidle,

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linked variously with those Somalis by diverse bonds. But the 84 three Somali tribes of the right bank (Hillibi, D[unknown]aûd, and M[unknown]obilên) are on tillable "black land"; and, as a matter of fact, they cultivate it, even though owning a notable amount of livestock.

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. Cf. Vol. II, pp. 257-258, 279 /see 25: Cerulli in this file/.

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